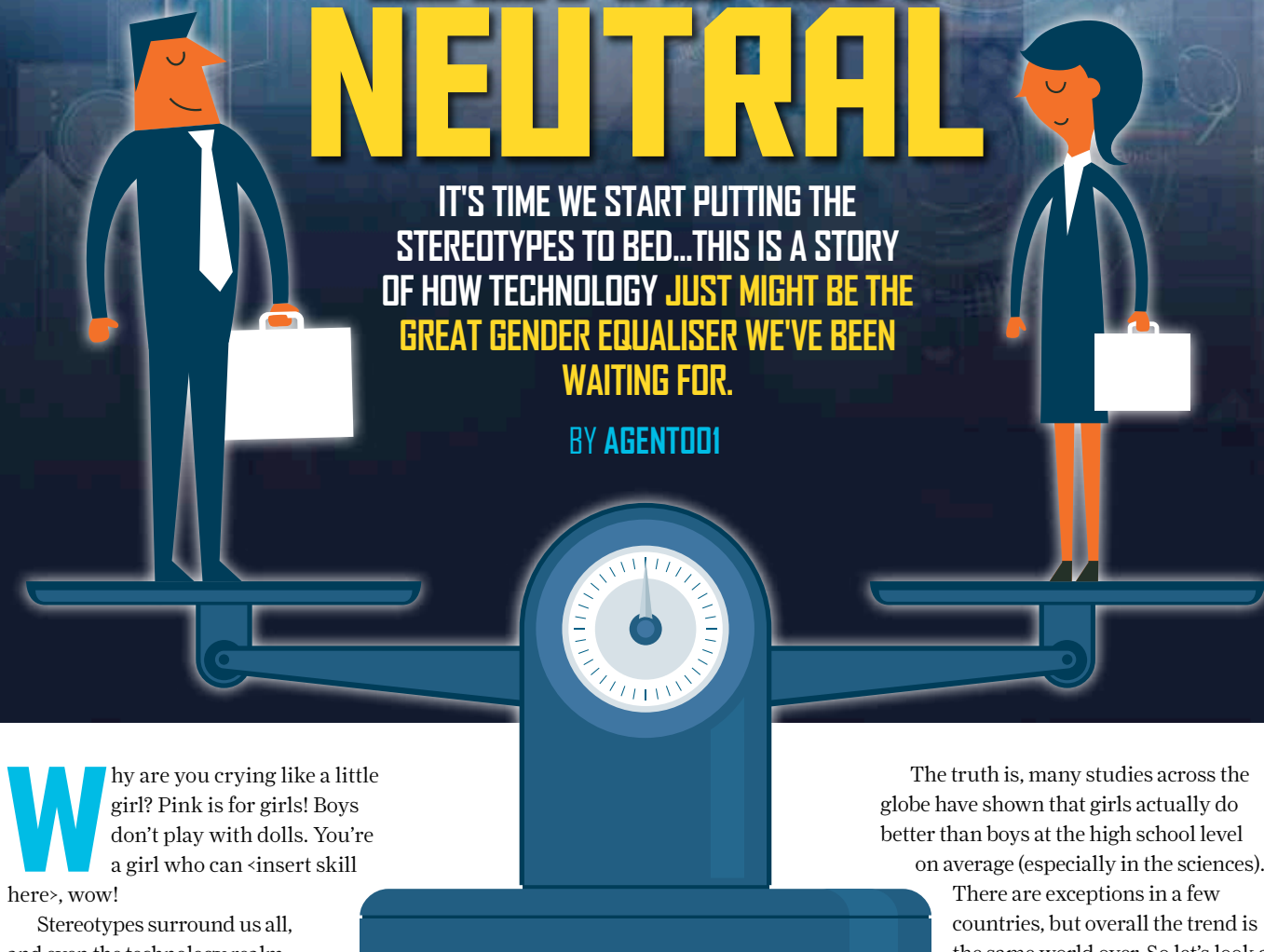


GENDER NEUTRAL

IT'S TIME WE START PUTTING THE STEREOTYPES TO BED...THIS IS A STORY OF HOW TECHNOLOGY **JUST MIGHT BE THE GREAT GENDER EQUALISER WE'VE BEEN WAITING FOR.**

BY AGENT001



Why are you crying like a little girl? Pink is for girls! Boys don't play with dolls. You're a girl who can <insert skill here>, wow!

Stereotypes surround us all, and even the technology realm isn't spared either. Actually, the technology world perhaps started out as a male-dominated domain due to mostly societal factors, but many decades of gender parity later, this bias promises to even out in time. Why? Because these days you can throw a rock in a city's business district, and you're likely to hit a person employed in a technology role. It's simple, technology is all encompassing by nature, and that's a good thing for gender equality. And we mean equality for both genders (masculine and feminine) and sex (male or female) here.

The wonderful thing about technology is that it's all just 1s and 0s ultimately. It will output the same result for a given question, no matter what type of genitals you have. Or so I hope!

Recently, there's been talk of trying to humanise technology. For example, personal assistants are being introduced, because apparently we prefer a person to a search box or a robot. Many will question why most of the personal assistants are female, and call that sexist. Are all the users of technology men? Why not a male voice? I'm not so butthurt about that though – for one thing, I assume most men and women would rather talk to a woman. Almost every modern adult man is used to being told what to do by a woman, or at least asking her for permission, and men are terrible at giving and asking for directions! (I jest, so hold off on the hate mail, for now.)

The truth is, many studies across the globe have shown that girls actually do better than boys at the high school level on average (especially in the sciences).

There are exceptions in a few countries, but overall the trend is the same world over. So let's look at aspects of tech that I think will end the great gender divide, or are at least steps in the right direction.

THE FREELANCER

The word "freelance" basically stems from ancient times, meaning a fighter who would work for money. Or a mercenary in other words. Very obviously male, and very macho. In those days, if you were a "free lance" you were definitely a man. Today, according to data from elance.com, if you're a freelancer in technology, you're more likely to be a woman! Oh how the tables have turned!

The obvious benefit of freelancing is that women who have chosen to put their careers on hold while being mothers can